wouldn’t resume until they were reunited about the way forward.

The guards gave her sideways glances, making her uneasy. When the bell rang for lunch, Léa—concerned she might miss Rose—didn’t want to leave the gate. But unable to ignore her growling stomach, she trudged to the canteen for the watery soup, her mother’s voice reminding her she would need it to keep up her strength.

Returning to the gate, she continued to wait. The morning fog had now lifted, but there was still no sign of Rose. As the church bells rang the hour and the afternoon advanced, she paced, hands behind her back, doubts and worries swirling inside her. Had Rose stumbled into trouble, like at the boardinghouse?

“Léa,” a man’s voice called out.

She spotted Maître Mallon pushing two bicycles—one on either side of him—up the hill leading to the camp. Léa stretched up on her toes, looking for her sister. No Rose.

Maître Mallon leaned the two bicycles against a bench. He showed the gendarme some papers. Léa expected Rose to crest the hill at any moment. Then the gendarme motioned for her to go inside the office. She sat at the table across from Maître Mallon.

“Léa, we don’t have much time,” Maître Mallon said urgently, “there’s something I need to—”

“Where’s Rose?”

“Don’t worry. Rose is waiting for you at the station.” He lifted a file from his leather satchel. “She helped me organize your release. If you’re willing. We took the liberty—”

“She agrees that I should go?” Léa leaned forward.

He nodded. “If that is what you want.”

“Yes, it is,” Léa said, relief flooding through her. What she dreaded most was that Rose wouldn’t want her to go and they’d argue and part on bad terms.

“All you have to do is sign these papers, agreeing to the conditions in the contract, and then we’ll go to Rose.” He raised his hand to his face, wiping beads of sweat from his forehead. It wasn’t like Maître Mallon to perspire, not in this cold. “There’s been a slight change,” he said. “I want you to understand completely before you sign.”

She waited.